Chapter 4

Meeting and Collaborating with Copilot

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Most meetings these days are conducted virtually, with participants spread over multiple locations and, often, multiple time zones. Just finding a good time to meet can often be a chore. Making sure everyone is prepared for the meeting and that the meeting isn't a waste of everyone's time is a whole different project.

Using a virtual meeting platform such as Microsoft Teams can help. Teams integrate with your calendar, email, and project management tools. It can streamline the process of planning, conducting, and following up on meetings.

Microsoft 365 Copilot in Teams enables meeting participants to ask questions about meetings, summarize the meetings, and more. Copilot may even make it possible for you to skip more meetings!

TECHNICAL STUFF Microsoft 365 Copilot Chat in Teams was recently rebranded as Business Chat, or "BizChat" for short. In this chapter, I use the original name.

Using Copilot in Microsoft Teams

To use Copilot during Teams meetings, you need to have a Copilot Pro or Microsoft Copilot 365 subscription. With an active subscription, you can access Copilot Chat in Teams by clicking the Chat icon on the left toolbar and then selecting Copilot Chat, as shown in Figure 4-1.

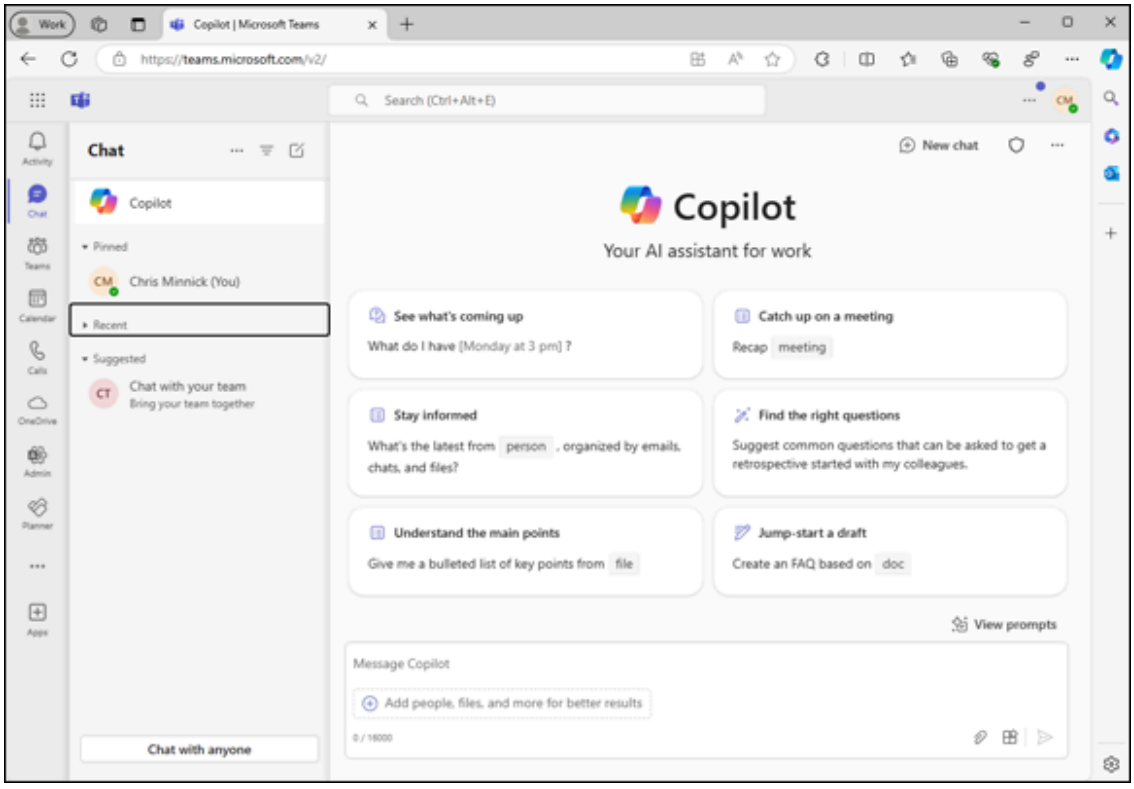


FIGURE 4-1: Microsoft 365 Copilot Chat in Teams.

Copilot Chat in Teams can answer questions about meetings that have already happened or that are scheduled. It can also generate responses by using emails, chats, and files.

Perhaps the most interesting things Copilot can do in Teams have to do with understanding and recapping meetings. To enable Copilot to help you during and after meetings, you must turn on transcriptions in Teams.

To enable transcriptions, click the Admin icon on the left toolbar, then click Home in the Admin navigation, and then click Set Up Meeting Preferences. The Set Up Meeting Preferences window will open. Look for the Allow Transcription option and enable it, as shown in Figure 4-2.

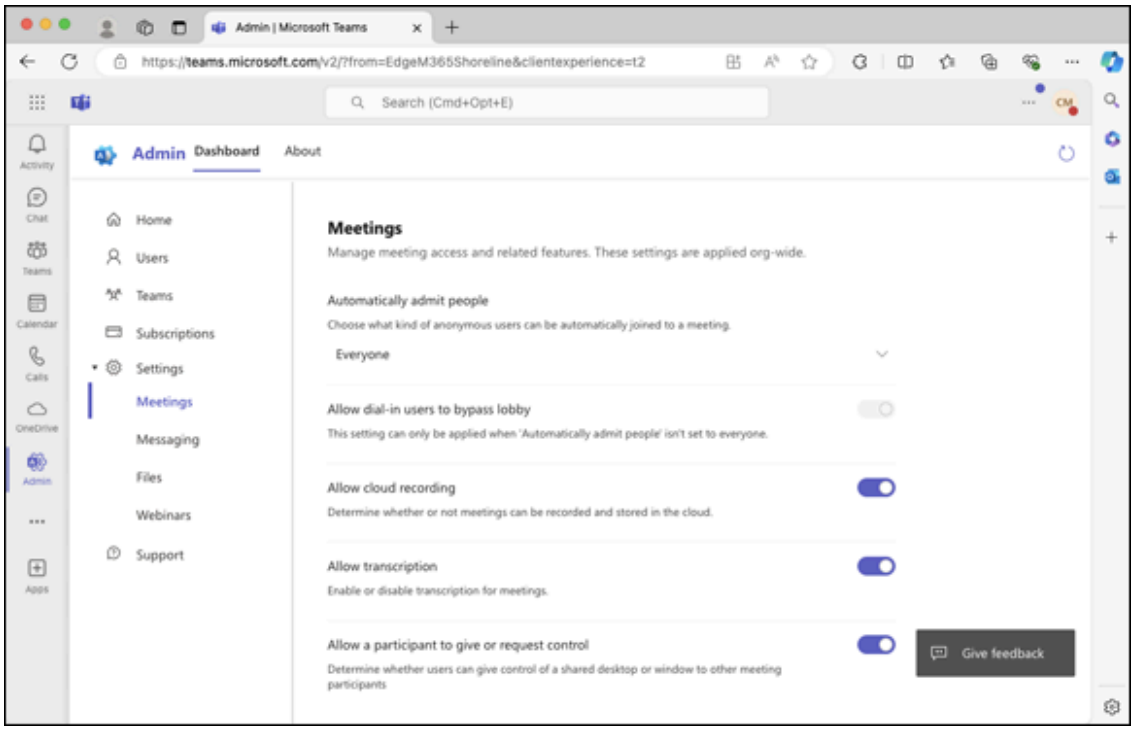


FIGURE 4-2: Allowing transcriptions.

Preparing for and setting up meetings

The first step in having a meeting is to figure out why you're having a meeting (and whether it's necessary). This may involve sending an email to the people who should be in the meeting, explaining what the meeting will be about, and then figuring out everyone's availability.

I need to meet with a colleague of mine to discuss a project I recently completed and to talk about process improvements I think we can make for similar projects in the future.

I opened Outlook and used the Draft with Copilot feature to write an email to my colleague Chris P. proposing a meeting and asking him about his availability.

I have a booking page set up through Outlook, which allows anyone to see my availability and schedule a meeting with me. Chris P. promptly sched-

uled a meeting with me on Monday.

TIP If you have a Microsoft 365 account, you can set up a booking page, too, by going to Settings --> Calendar in Outlook. After you have a booking page, you can specify your availability for different types of meetings and then include a link to your booking page in your email signature or on your website.

When you have a scheduled meeting, you can open the meeting details in your calendar. At the bottom of the meeting details is a link called Add an Agenda, which is highlighted in Figure 4-3.

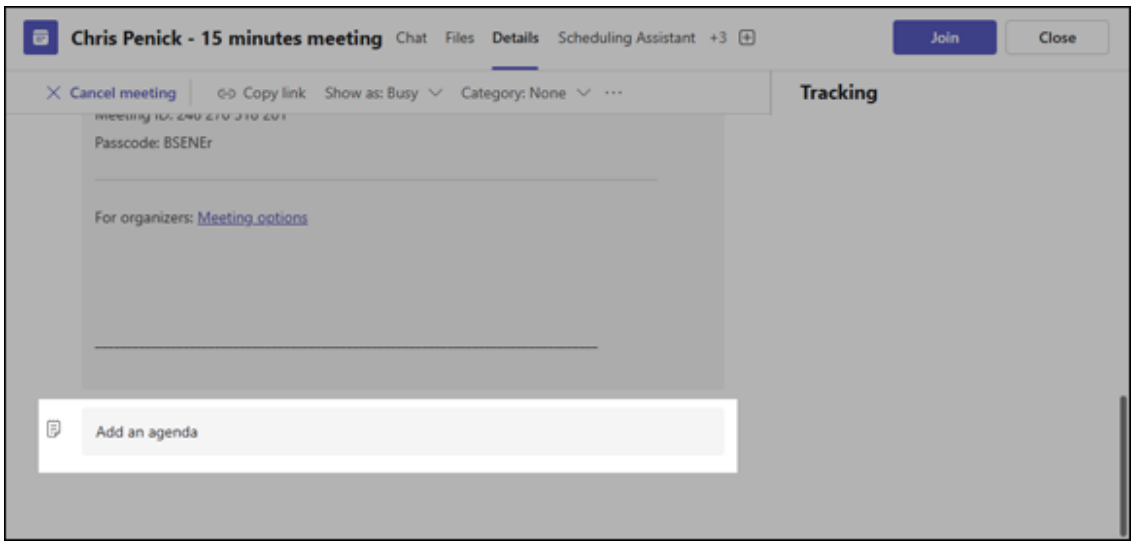


FIGURE 4-3: The Add an Agenda link.

Clicking the Add an Agenda link opens a new window with three sections: Topics, Meeting Notes, and Follow-up Tasks. This window is actually an embedded view from your Microsoft Loop account.

TIP *Microsoft Loop* is an online collaborative workspace that helps people gather and organize information about projects.

When you click your mouse into one of the three sections in the Loop window, the Copilot logo appears to the right of the selected line, as

shown in Figure 4-4.

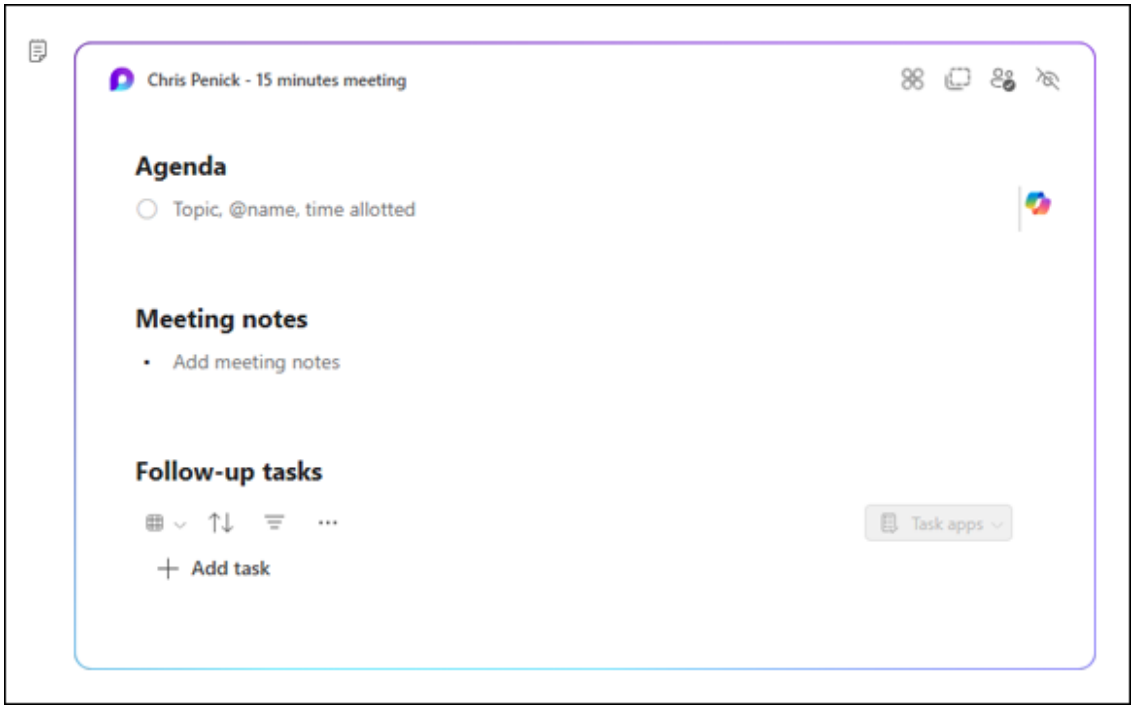


FIGURE 4-4: The Copilot logo in the Agenda window.

Clicking the Copilot logo opens a prompt input area with several buttons below it: Create, Brainstorm, Blueprint, and Describe. Each of these buttons populates the prompt text input area with a sample prompt, as shown in Figure 4-5.

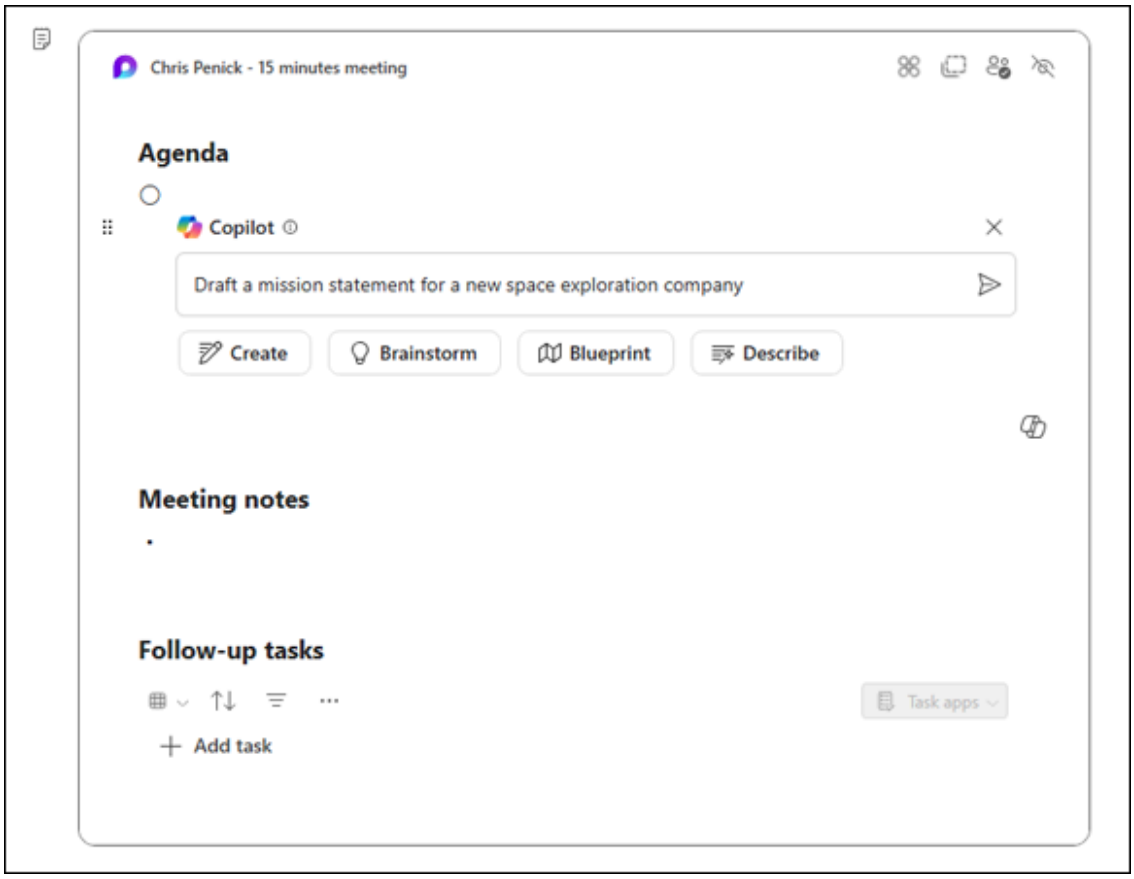


FIGURE 4-5: Viewing sample prompts to populate the agenda.

I entered some details about what I expected the meeting with Chris P. would be about, and I asked Copilot to generate an agenda. Copilot broke apart my sentence into eight numbered agenda items with two or three bullet points beneath each one.

My original prompt and the beginning of the generated agenda are shown in Figure 4-6.

The agenda that Copilot created wasn't bad, although it was longer than I thought was necessary, and it contained a couple of unnecessary points. In all, I estimate that using Copilot saved me about 15 minutes by giving me something to start with for writing the agenda — if I even would have bothered to write an agenda for the meeting without Copilot. Honestly, I probably wouldn't have bothered. But I'm feeling good about the chances of this meeting resulting in something good.

The other two items in the meeting agenda window are Meeting Notes and Follow-up Tasks. I'll have to wait until after the meeting next Monday to fill those in!

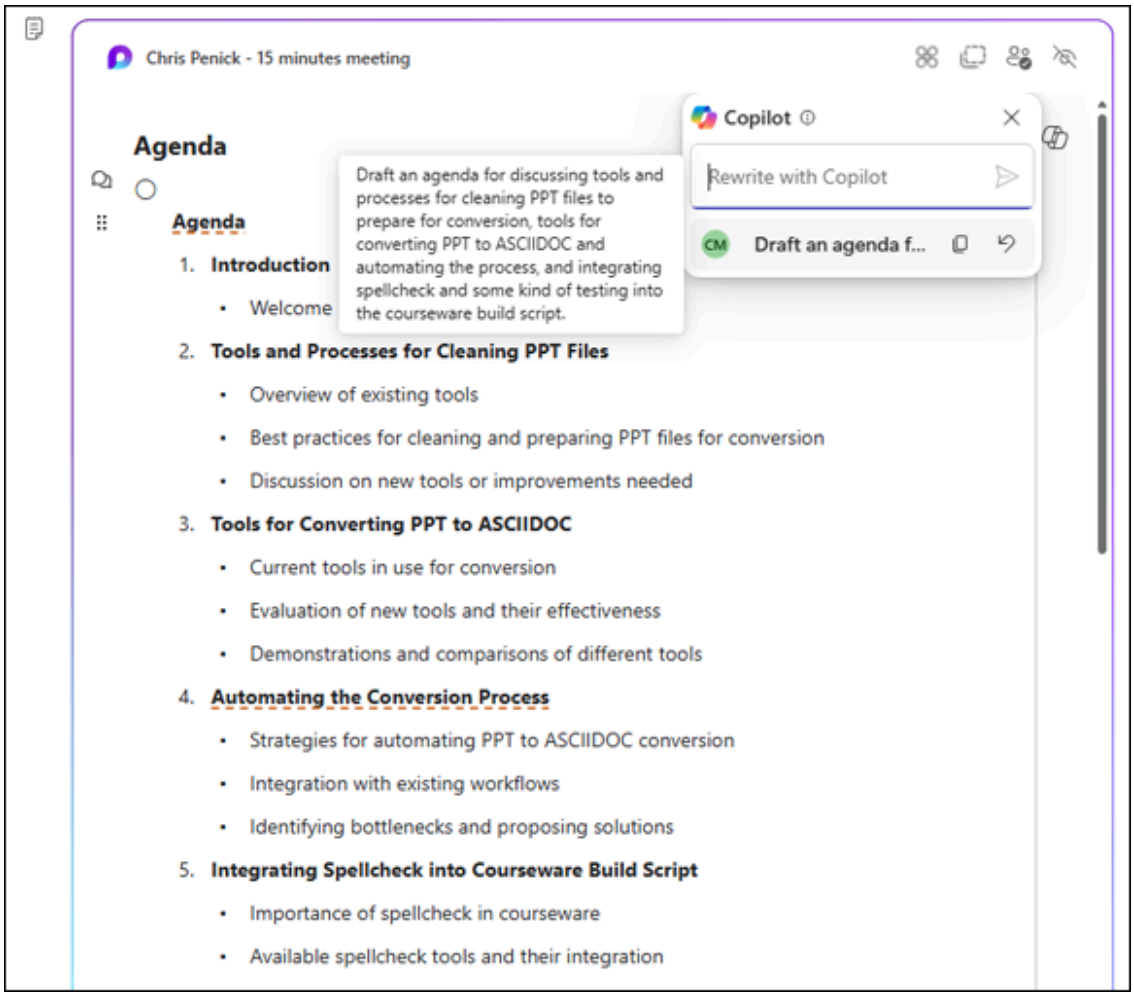


FIGURE 4-6: Copilot's generated agenda.

The last step in creating the agenda is to share it with Chris P. Since he isn't part of my Microsoft 365 organization, I clicked the link at the bottom of the embedded Loop window to go to the project in the Loop app itself.

At the top of the Loop page for the meeting is a Share button that you can use to copy a link to the page and specify who has access. Unfortunately, it's not possible to share a Loop page with someone outside of your organization.

I clicked the Send Update button in the meeting details, and it sent an email to Chris P., but that email didn't contain the agenda. So, I copied the agenda from the embedded Loop window, pasted it into the Teams meeting invitation itself, and sent another meeting update.

TIP It's helpful to have a friend or colleague who won't be annoyed by extra messages as you're figuring out what can and can't be done in Teams and with Copilot in Teams.

Getting real-time meeting assistance

Copilot can help with various tasks while you're in a Teams meeting. To allow Copilot to answer questions about the meeting, you must turn on transcription for the meeting. If you already followed the steps at the beginning of this chapter to enable transcriptions in Teams, you'll be able to turn on transcriptions for an individual meeting by clicking the More button at the top of the screen, selecting Record and Transcribe, and then selecting Start Transcription, as shown in Figure 4-7.

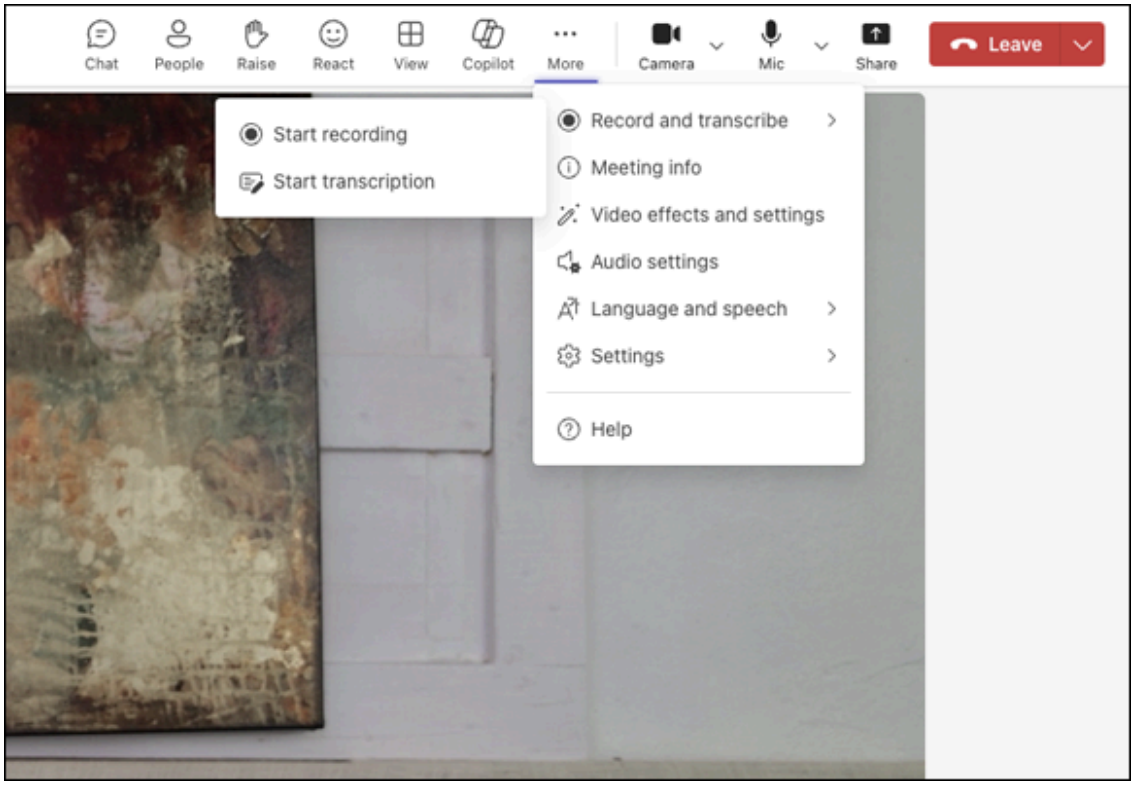


FIGURE 4-7: Enabling transcription.

With the transcription function enabled, a live transcription of the meeting along with labels indicating who's speaking will be accessible to all participants in the meeting. This live transcription is what Copilot uses to answer questions about the meeting.

To access Copilot in Teams while you're in a meeting, click the Copilot icon in the top toolbar of Teams. A Copilot sidebar will appear on the left, as shown in Figure 4-8.

You can ask Copilot anything about the meeting, and it will consult the transcript and generate a response. Some of the suggested prompts that Copilot lists under the More Prompts menu in the prompt input box are

- Recap meeting so far
- List action items
- Suggest follow-up questions
- What questions are unresolved?
- List different perspectives by topic
- List main ideas we discussed
- Generate meeting notes

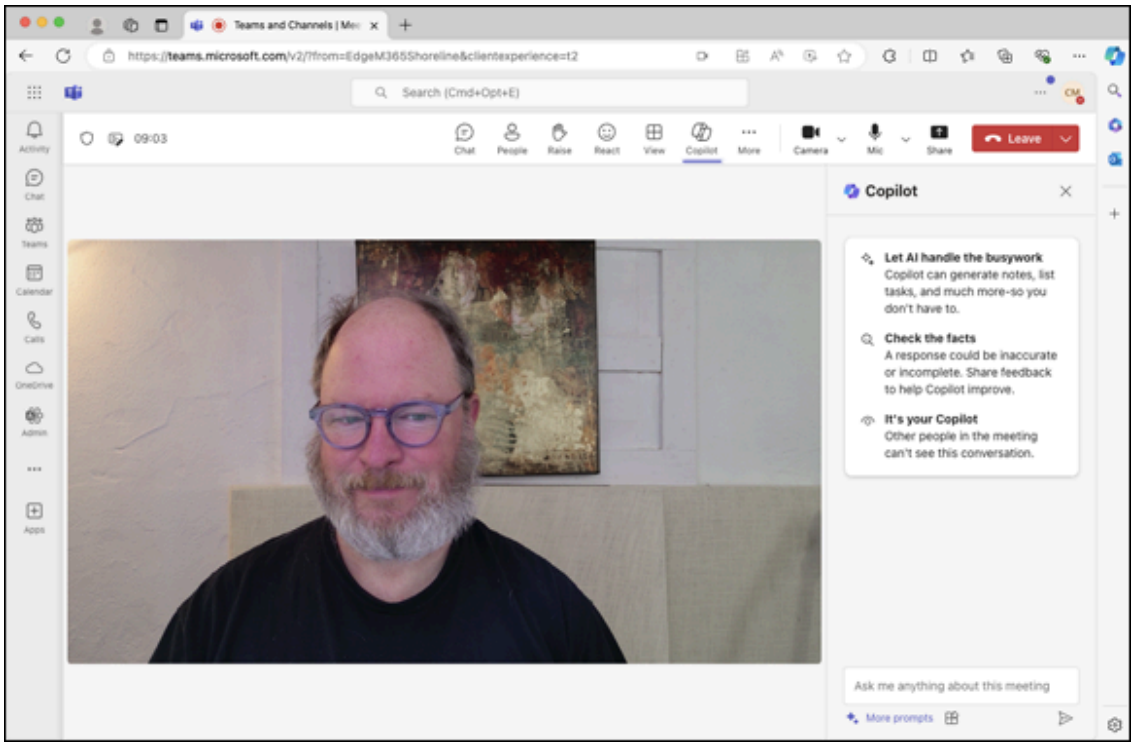


FIGURE 4-8: The Copilot sidebar in Teams.

During my meeting with Chris P., we found the transcription to be highly accurate, and having Copilot answer questions about the meeting worked well, too.

After we'd been talking for about ten minutes, I asked Copilot to create a summary of the meeting so far, and its response was accurate and even useful for helping me steer the conversation.

In a meeting with just two people, having access to Copilot to answer questions about the meeting might be unnecessary and distract from the meeting. However, in larger meetings, you may wonder how you ever survived a meeting without it.

For meetings of any size, the really interesting and useful part of having Copilot in Teams comes after the meeting is finished.

Accessing post-meeting summaries

Shortly after you finish a meeting, a message like the one in Figure 4-9 will appear in the Chat window of Teams to tell you that the recording is ready and to give you the option to view a recap of the meeting or the meeting transcript, video, or notes.

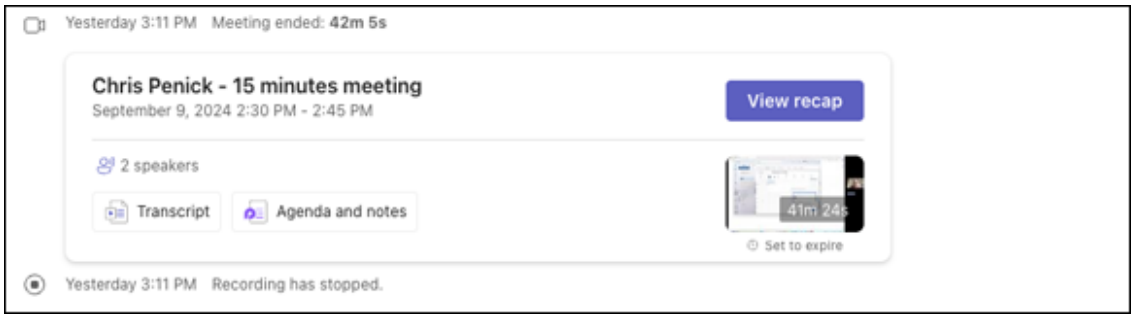


FIGURE 4-9: Your recap is ready.

The recap screen includes a video window, the agenda, AI-generated meeting notes, and the transcript of the meeting.

Figure 4-10 shows the meeting recap of my meeting.

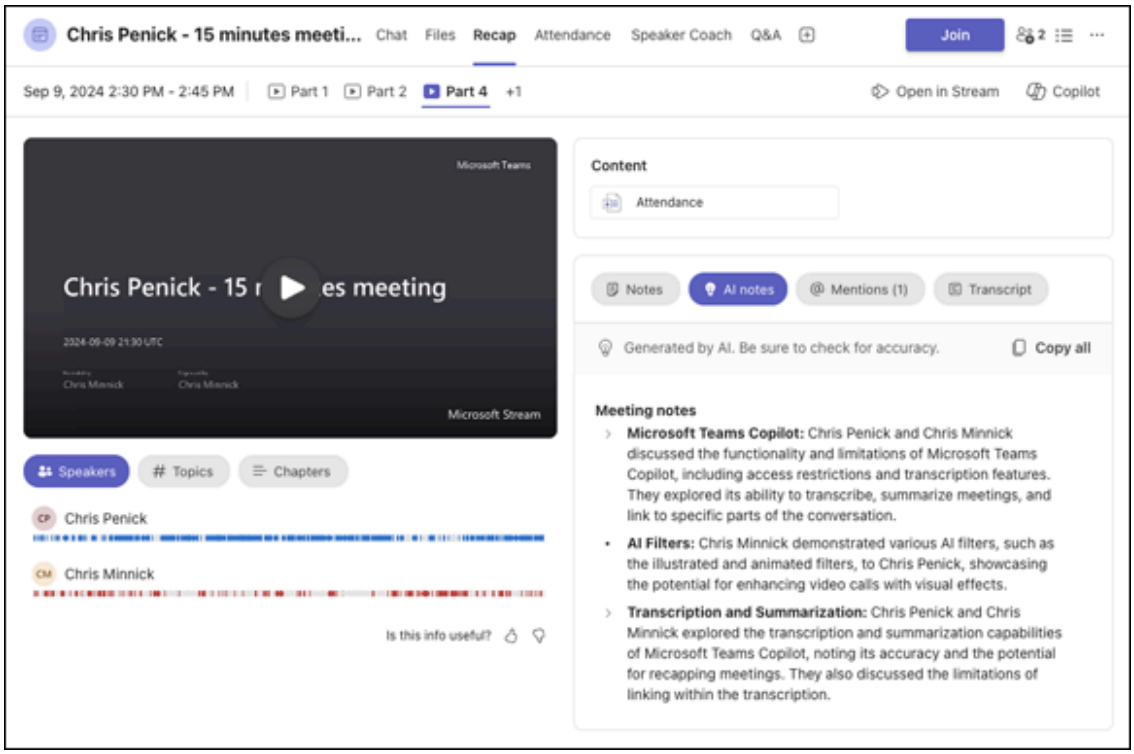


FIGURE 4-10: Getting a recap.

Below the video window are three buttons to view different ways to visualize the meeting:

- The first button, Speakers, shows when each attendee was speaking.
- The second button, Topics, shows each topic that was discussed in the meeting.
- The third button, Chapters, uses the same topic divisions as the Topics view but shows a screenshot from each topic.

Clicking in one of these visualizations takes you directly to that point in the video.

In the upper-right corner of the Recap screen is a Copilot button; it opens the same Copilot in Teams sidebar that you had access to while the meeting was going on. Here, you can ask any question about the meeting, and Copilot will consult the transcript to answer it.

I tried out each of the suggested prompts in Copilot and Teams and found the action items one to be especially useful. It scanned the transcript for things that each attendee agreed to do after the meeting and gave a summary of each one. This feature will be invaluable for ensuring that meetings aren't just a waste of everyone's time while also not requiring everyone to rely on someone in the meeting to take notes.

Understanding the Limitations of Copilot in Teams

Having an AI assistant before, during, and after a virtual meeting has the potential to make meetings more useful and memorable. The integration between Teams and other Microsoft 365 applications makes sense and generally works very well.

However, some limitations to Copilot in Teams may cause users to struggle with it at first. These limitations include

- **Copilot's knowledge of the meeting is entirely dependent on the transcript.** If important visuals are presented during the meeting, you can, of course, review the video to see those. But, asking Copilot questions about something that doesn't come through in the transcript won't be successful.
- **Copilot in Teams doesn't integrate with Copilot in other apps.** You can ask Copilot in Teams to create the text for an email to the participants, but Copilot can only generate the text. It's up to you to copy the text and paste it into an email. Likewise, asking Copilot to create a PowerPoint presentation from the meeting recap will just result in a text-only list of potential slides you could create with PowerPoint.
- **Each participant in the meeting who wants to access Copilot in Teams must have Copilot Pro or Microsoft 365 Copilot subscriptions.** There's no way for the meeting organizer to give everyone in the meeting access to Copilot during the meeting.
- **Meeting transcription (and ideally recording) must be enabled to take advantage of Copilot in Teams.** Teams doesn't currently have a way to set transcription and recording to be on by default. So, you have to remember to enable these for each meeting. In my experimenting with Copilot in Teams, I did forget to enable transcription at first; I had to sign out of the meeting, enable transcription, and then rejoin to be able to use Copilot.

None of these limitations outweigh the benefits of having Copilot in Teams, and I expect that some of them will be resolved in future versions of Microsoft 365 and Teams.

In my dream world, I'd have to go to about ten percent of the meetings that I currently have. But, if I can't have that, I'd settle for making meetings more useful. Copilot in Teams has the potential to improve the experience of having meetings by making it easier for everyone in the meeting to be reminded of what happened in previous meetings, to ensure that

excellent meeting notes are kept, and to follow up on what decisions and actions were agreed to during the meeting.